

Your Google Business Profile Set Up for the AI Era

The step-by-step guide to turning your GBP into the single most powerful AI visibility tool your local business has.

WHAT YOU'LL ACHIEVE

By the end of this guide, your Google Business Profile will be **fully optimised for AI search** — complete, active, and structured so that Google AI Overviews, ChatGPT, and Perplexity all have the information they need to recommend your business with confidence.

7×

more likely to be cited in AI answers
with a complete GBP

30+

days without a GBP update =
measurable drop in AI citations

42%

of GBP views now come from AI-
powered search features

What you'll learn in this guide

Google Business Profile is not just a listing — it's the single most important signal Google's AI uses to decide whether to recommend your business. Every AI Overview you appear in, every ChatGPT recommendation that mentions your name, every Perplexity citation that sends someone to your website — all of them start with whether Google trusts you. And Google's trust starts with your GBP.

This guide walks you through the entire process, from claiming or verifying your profile to the weekly habits that keep you visible. No technical knowledge required — just a Google account and a business.

01

Claim and verify your GBP — or fix a listing that already exists but isn't under your control

02

Complete every field — the ones most businesses skip and the exact ones AI looks at

03

Set the right category — the single field that determines which searches you're eligible to appear in

04

Build the activity habits — photos, posts, and review responses that keep AI citing you

05

Write a description that AI quotes — specific structure and phrasing that makes your business easy for AI to recommend

06

Understand the AI connection — exactly how GBP data feeds into Google AI Overviews and other AI platforms

Important before you start: Everything in this guide applies whether you have a physical shop, work from home, or visit customers at their location. Google Business Profile works for all three — we'll cover the right setup for each.

Why your GBP is your AI search foundation

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Your Google Business Profile is like your business's entry in an official directory — but one that every AI system on the planet reads first. When ChatGPT, Google's AI Overviews, or Perplexity try to answer "who's the best plumber near me," they all check the same thing: what does Google know about this business? Your GBP is where that information lives.

In 2026, Google AI Overviews appear on roughly 15% of all Google searches — and that number grows every month. When someone searches "emergency electrician in Leeds" and an AI Overview appears, it typically names two or three businesses. Those businesses didn't get there by accident. They got there because their GBP told Google's AI exactly what they do, where they do it, that they're trustworthy, and that they're currently active.

The good news is that most local businesses have barely touched their GBP since they first set it up (or it was auto-created by Google). This means a relatively small amount of work puts you significantly ahead of your local competition in AI search — not because you've done something clever, but simply because you've done something they haven't.

64%

of GBP listings are incomplete or contain outdated information

7×

more AI Overview appearances for businesses with fully complete GBPs

42%

of all GBP views now come from AI-powered search features in 2026

Let's build yours properly.

Section 1: Claiming and verifying your profile

Before you can optimise anything, you need to own it. This section covers finding, claiming, and verifying your Google Business Profile — whether you're starting from scratch or taking control of an existing listing.

Step 1: Find out if a listing already exists

Google often auto-creates business listings from information it finds across the web. Your business might already have a GBP that you've never seen — possibly with wrong information on it that's actively hurting your AI visibility right now.

1 Go to Google Maps

Search for your business name plus your town or postcode (e.g. "Dave's Plumbing Sheffield"). Look for a result with your business name and address.

2 Search Google directly

Type your business name in Google. Look for a Knowledge Panel — the box on the right side of the results that shows business details. If it's there, a listing exists.

3 Go to business.google.com

Sign in with your Google account. If Google has automatically suggested your business, it will appear here.

HEADS UP

If you find a listing that shows wrong information — old address, wrong phone number, someone else managing it — don't panic. You can claim it and correct it. Google has a process for exactly this situation.

Step 2: Claim or create your listing

If a listing exists but isn't claimed by you, click "Own this business?" on Google Maps or search for it in business.google.com and select "Claim this business." If no listing exists, click "Add your business to Google" in business.google.com.

Step 3: Verify your business

Google needs to confirm you're a real, legitimate business at the location you've listed. This is called verification, and it's non-negotiable — an unverified listing has severely limited AI visibility. Google offers several verification methods depending on your business type:

- ✓ **Video verification** — The most common method in 2026. Record a short video showing your business location, your signage, and your equipment or workspace. Upload it in the GBP app. Google reviews it within a few days.
- ✓ **Postcard verification** — Google sends a postcard to your business address with a code. Enter the code in your GBP. Takes 5-14 days. Only available for businesses with a physical address.
- ✓ **Phone verification** — Google calls or texts your business phone with a code. Available for some business types and locations.
- ✓ **Email verification** — Available for some business types. Google sends a code to your business email.
- ✓ **Live video call** — A Google representative calls you via video while you show your business. Used for certain business types.

PRO TIP

For video verification, the video doesn't need to be polished or professional. It just needs to clearly show your business signage/name, your address or location, and proof that you work there (equipment, stock, workspace). A smartphone video filmed in one continuous take is perfectly acceptable.

Choose whichever method is available and complete it as quickly as possible. Your GBP has very limited AI visibility until it's verified, so this is your immediate priority.

HEADS UP

If your business is home-based, you can hide your home address in GBP while still being verified. You'll set a service area instead of displaying your home address. We cover this in Section 5.

Section 2: The fields that matter most for AI

Most GBP guides tell you to "fill in all the fields." But not all fields are equal when it comes to AI visibility. Some fields are read by Google's AI on almost every local query. Others are largely ignored. This section focuses on the ones that matter.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Imagine Google's AI is a new employee trying to answer customer calls. Each field in your GBP is a fact they can tell a customer. "What do they do?" — your description. "Where are they?" — your address. "Are they any good?" — your reviews. The more complete and specific your answers, the more confidently the AI can recommend you.

Business name

Your business name in GBP should be your **exact legal trading name** — nothing more. Don't add keywords, your city name, or descriptors that aren't part of your actual business name. "Dave's Plumbing" is correct. "Dave's Plumbing — Heating & Gas Engineers Sheffield" is keyword stuffing and violates Google's policies.

Google actively enforces this and can suspend listings that stuff keywords into the business name. More importantly, AI systems treat keyword-stuffed names as less trustworthy because they look manufactured rather than genuine.

HEADS UP

Your business name in GBP must match your business name on your website, Facebook page, and any other directory listing. Inconsistency is one of the most common reasons businesses don't appear in AI local recommendations. We cover this in detail in Module 3.

Business category — the single most important field

Your primary business category is the most important field in your entire GBP. It determines which types of search queries you're eligible to appear in. Get it wrong and you'll be invisible for the searches that matter to you — no matter how good everything else is.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Categories are like the section of a library your book is filed in. If your plumbing book ends up in the cookery section, people looking for plumbing books will never find it — even if it's the best plumbing book in existence. Category placement determines findability before any other factor.

How to choose the right primary category

Google has thousands of categories, and choosing the right one requires being as specific as possible while staying accurate to what you actually do. Here's the process:

- 1 Be specific, not broad**

"Boiler Installation Service" is better than "Plumber." "Personal Injury Attorney" is better than "Lawyer." The more specific, the fewer competitors you share a category with.
- 2 Search what your customers search**

Think about the exact phrase your ideal customer types when they need you. Search that on Google Maps. Look at the categories your top competitors use. Those are your category options.
- 3 Pick the one that fits your most profitable service**

If you do plumbing and heating but 80% of your revenue comes from boiler installations, your primary category should reflect boilers — not general plumbing.
- 4 Add secondary categories for everything else**

You can add multiple secondary categories to capture other service types. Use them — they add coverage without diluting your primary focus.

PRO TIP

Business description — write it for AI to quote

Your business description is 750 characters of pure AI visibility opportunity. Most businesses write a vague corporate-sounding paragraph that AI can't do anything useful with. You're going to do better.

Google's AI actually reads your business description and uses it to answer questions about your business. The key is to write in clear declarative sentences that directly state facts — because AI loves facts it can quote.

The structure that works

Think of your description in four parts, each covering a question Google's AI might be asked:

1 Who you are and what you do

One clear sentence. "[Business name] is a [specific service type] based in [location], serving [area]." No fluff. Just the facts.

2 What makes you specifically different

One concrete fact — not "we pride ourselves on quality" but "we respond to all enquiries within 2 hours and offer same-day call-outs for emergencies."

3 Your key services

List your three or four main services in plain English. Not marketing language — just the services. AI uses this to match you to service-specific queries.

4 Your coverage and availability

Specifically where you work and when. "We cover Manchester, Salford, Stockport, and surrounding areas, Monday to Saturday 7am–7pm."

Example description that AI can work with: "Sheffield Boiler Centre installs, services, and repairs gas boilers and central heating systems across Sheffield, Rotherham, and Barnsley. We are Gas Safe registered and respond to all heating emergencies within 4 hours, 7 days a week. Our services include new boiler installation, annual boiler service, power flushing, and landlord gas safety certificates. Family-run since 2008."

Notice what that description does: it states the location clearly, lists specific services, includes a specific claim (4 hours, 7 days), includes a trust signal (Gas Safe, since 2008), and covers the service area. AI can quote any part of that to answer a customer question.

Address, phone number, and opening hours

These three fields are what AI uses to answer the most basic local search questions: "Where are they?" "How do I contact them?" "Are they open right now?" If any of them are wrong or missing, AI simply can't confidently recommend you.

Address

Enter your address exactly as it appears on official mail you receive. This sounds obvious, but even small differences — "St" versus "Street," "Rd" versus "Road," flat number formatting — create inconsistencies that reduce your trustworthiness score across AI systems. We cover this in depth in Module 3.

If you don't have a customer-facing premises (you work from home or visit clients), do not enter your home address publicly. Instead, set a service area (covered in Section 5). Google specifically supports this — you can be verified and fully visible without displaying a home address.

Phone number

Use your primary business phone number — the same one on your website, invoices, and any directory listings. If you use a mobile as your business number, that's fine, but it needs to be consistent everywhere. Don't use a tracking number in GBP unless that same tracking number appears everywhere else.

Opening hours

This field is read by Google's AI in real time to answer questions like "are they open on Sunday?" Set your hours accurately and update them for bank holidays and seasonal changes. A business that shows as "open" when it's actually closed is a credibility disaster — not just for human visitors but for AI systems that use your hours as a reliability signal.

PRO TIP

Use Google's "special hours" feature to set holiday hours in advance — Christmas, bank holidays, and any closures. This prevents AI from telling someone you're open when you're not, and it signals that your profile is actively maintained.

Website link

Always link to your actual website homepage — not a social media page, not a booking platform. Your website is where AI goes for the full picture of your business. If you don't have a website yet, this is one of the reasons Module 4 exists.

Services and products — the hidden goldmine

Most businesses fill in the basic GBP fields and stop. They never touch the Services section. This is a significant mistake — and one that works heavily in your favour if you're reading this, because your competitors are probably making it too.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Your category tells AI you're a plumber. Your services list tells AI you do boiler installation, pipe repair, bathroom fitting, and emergency callouts. Without the services list, AI might recommend you for general plumbing queries but miss you entirely for "bathroom fitter near me" or "emergency gas leak" — which might be exactly your most profitable work.

How to add services properly

1 Go to your GBP dashboard → Edit profile → Services

Google will suggest services based on your category. Accept the ones that apply, but don't stop there.

2 Add custom services for everything you do

Click "Add custom service" and enter each specific service you offer. Be specific: "Boiler Installation" and "Boiler Repair" are two separate services — don't combine them into "Boiler Services."

3 Add a price if you can

Even a "from £X" price is better than nothing. AI uses pricing information to answer budget-related queries.

4 Write a description for each service

A 1-2 sentence description of each service gives AI more material to work with. Keep it factual: what the service is, what's included, any relevant details.

HEADS UP

If you offer a service that doesn't appear in Google's suggestions and isn't available as a custom service in your category, don't add it as a fake category — that violates GBP policies and can get your listing suspended. Instead, describe it in your business description and on your website.

Attributes — the trust signals AI loves

Attributes are the tick-box characteristics that appear in your GBP: "Women-led," "Identifies as LGBTQ+ friendly," "Veteran-led," "Accepts credit cards," "Free parking," "Wheelchair accessible," and dozens more depending on your business type.

Don't skip these because they seem minor. AI search increasingly uses attributes to match businesses to specific searches. "Dog-friendly café near me," "accessible dentist Leeds," "women-led accountant" — these are real searches, and attributes are how you appear in them.

Go through every available attribute and tick everything that genuinely applies to your business. Don't tick things that don't apply — that creates false impressions and can lead to bad reviews from people who expected something you don't offer.

Questions & Answers — seed it yourself

The Q&A section of your GBP allows anyone — including you — to ask and answer questions about your business. Most business owners don't realise they can populate this themselves, and they should.

PRO TIP

Log in to Google Maps (not GBP dashboard — you need to do this via Maps directly), find your listing, and use the Q&A section to add the most common questions you get asked along with clear, specific answers. "Do you offer same-day appointments?" "Do you cover [specific town]?" "Is there parking?" These become content that AI can directly quote in local search answers.

Aim for 5-8 Q&As covering your most common customer questions. Update them if answers change (prices, availability, services). This is content that almost no competitor is adding deliberately — giving you a genuine AI citation advantage.

HEADS UP

Anyone can answer questions on your GBP, not just you. Check your Q&A section regularly to make sure no one has posted incorrect information that AI might pick up. If you see a wrong answer, add a correct one and flag the inaccurate one to Google.

Section 3: Photos — your most active AI signal

Photos are not just about looking good. They're one of the strongest signals of an active, trustworthy business. Google's AI tracks photo activity as part of its engagement model — a profile with regular new photos consistently outperforms one that went dark.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Imagine two restaurants. One has 200 photos but the most recent is from 2022. The other has 30 photos but uploads a new one every week. Which one does Google's AI think is more likely to still be open and serving good food? The active one — every time. Recency of activity is a trust signal, not just quantity.

What photos to add

Google categorises GBP photos into types. Each type serves a different purpose in AI search:

- ✓ **Exterior photos** — Your shopfront or building exterior, from multiple angles if possible. Helps AI (and humans) identify your location.
- ✓ **Interior photos** — What it looks like inside. Creates trust that you're a real, established business.
- ✓ **Team photos** — You and/or your staff. One of the strongest trust signals — it's hard to fake a genuine team photo.
- ✓ **Work/product photos** — Jobs you've completed, products you sell, services in action. The most valuable type for AI because they demonstrate you actually do what you say you do.
- ✓ **Logo** — Upload your business logo as a formal logo photo. This is how Google knows which logo to show in search results.

The weekly photo habit

Add at least one new photo every week. It doesn't need to be a professional photo — a smartphone photo of a job you've just completed is ideal. It proves you're active, it's recent, and it shows your work.

Businesses that drop below one photo per month see measurable drops in AI Overview appearances. Businesses that upload weekly consistently maintain and improve their standing.

Photo quality — what actually matters

You don't need a professional photographer. But there are a few things that will make your photos work harder:

- ✓ **Good lighting** — Natural daylight is ideal. Avoid dark, blurry, or badly lit photos — Google's image quality algorithms can detect low-quality images and weight them lower.
- ✓ **Show the actual work** — A "before and after" of a job you've done is significantly more powerful than a stock photo. Real evidence beats generic imagery every time.
- ✓ **Include people occasionally** — A photo of you working, or a happy customer (with their permission), is a strong trust signal that AI notices.
- ✓ **Avoid logos/text overlays on photos** — Google's guidelines discourage heavily branded or text-heavy photos. Keep your photos authentic.
- ✓ **Minimum resolution: 720px on the short side** — Modern smartphones all exceed this, so shoot in your phone's standard mode (not social media crop).

PRO TIP — BUILD A PHOTO HABIT IN 30 SECONDS

When you finish a job or serve a customer, take one quick photo before you leave or before they go. It takes 30 seconds. At the end of each week, upload the best one to GBP. That's it — one photo per week, consistently. Set a recurring calendar reminder for "GBP photo" every Friday afternoon and you'll never fall behind.

Video on GBP

GBP also supports short videos (up to 30 seconds, 75MB max). Video is an even stronger engagement signal than photos, but most businesses don't use it. A 15-second walkthrough of your workspace, or a quick demonstration of your most popular service, will be noticed by both Google's algorithms and potential customers. If you already post videos to social media, repurpose them here.

HEADS UP

Customers can also add photos and videos to your GBP listing. Check your listing regularly and report anything inappropriate or inaccurate via Google's "Report a problem" feature. Customer photos are also weighted by Google's AI as evidence of your business's authenticity, so don't discourage them — they help you.

Section 4: Google Posts — your freshness signal

Google Posts are short updates you publish directly to your GBP — similar to social media posts but they appear in Google Search and Maps results. They're one of the clearest signals to Google's AI that your business is currently active.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Google's AI is always trying to figure out whether a business is still operating. A listing with no posts in 30 days looks like a business that might have closed or stopped caring. A listing with a post from this week looks like an active, engaged business worth recommending. Posts are your way of saying "we're still here and we're paying attention."

Research shows that businesses that go more than 30 days without a GBP post see a measurable decline in how often they're cited in Google AI Overviews. The inverse is also true — businesses that post at least twice a month consistently maintain stronger AI visibility than those that don't.

Types of posts and when to use them

- ✓ **Updates** — General news about your business. A new service, a completed project, a team member joining, a change to opening hours. This is your default post type.
- ✓ **Offers** — If you're running a promotion or discount, use this type. It includes a start and end date and a call-to-action button.
- ✓ **Events** — If you're running or attending an event. Less relevant for most local service businesses but useful for retailers and hospitality.

What to write in a post

Posts don't need to be long or clever. They just need to be specific and genuine. Here's what works:

- ✓ "We just finished a full bathroom renovation in [town] — new suite, wetwall, and underfloor heating. Here's how it came out."
- ✓ "We're now offering weekend boiler services for customers who can't take time off work during the week."
- ✓ "Thanks to all our customers who've left reviews this month — they genuinely help local families find trustworthy tradespeople."

Your posting strategy

You don't need to post every day. You need to post consistently. The minimum threshold to maintain AI visibility is **twice a month**. The level that actively improves it is **once a week**.

Here's a simple weekly posting schedule for a local service business:

1

Monday

Post about availability for the week or a recent job you're proud of. Photo included.

2

Every other Thursday

Share something genuinely useful — a tip, a warning, an update about your services. This builds authority and gives AI more factual content to associate with your business.

If that feels like too much to start with, just commit to one post every two weeks. Even that simple habit puts you ahead of most local businesses.

PRO TIP — BATCH YOUR POSTS

Set aside 30 minutes once a month to write 2-3 posts in advance. You can't schedule GBP posts natively, but you can write them in a notes app and copy-paste them into GBP when the time comes. Having them ready removes the friction of "what do I write?" in the moment.

Posts expire after 7 days for updates

Standard GBP update posts become less visible after about 7 days (though they stay in your post history). This is another reason consistency matters — fresh posts keep pushing your content in front of both human searchers and AI systems. Offers stay visible until their end date.

HEADS UP

Don't write posts that are purely promotional or keyword-stuffed. Google's AI reads posts as signals of genuine business activity, not as ad copy. A post that reads like an advert ("BEST PLUMBER IN SHEFFIELD — CALL NOW") is treated with less trust than one that reads like a business update. Be human.

Section 5: Reviews — the AI's evidence of trust

Reviews are the single most powerful third-party signal that AI search systems use to evaluate your business. Not just your star rating — the content of your reviews, how you respond to them, and how recently you've received them all feed into how AI decides whether to recommend you.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

Imagine AI search as a friend doing research before recommending a business to you. They'd check reviews the way you do — not just the star average but what people actually said. "Fixed my boiler in under two hours, very polite, didn't leave a mess" tells them far more than 47 reviews that just say "great service." AI works the same way — it reads the actual content, not just the score.

What AI looks for in your reviews

Google's AI processes review content for specific signals that help it confidently recommend you:

- ✓ **Service mentions** — Reviews that name specific services ("he replaced the thermostat") confirm what you do to AI systems
- ✓ **Location mentions** — Reviews that mention your area ("came out to us in Rotherham same day") confirm where you work
- ✓ **Outcome descriptions** — Reviews that describe a result ("the boiler has been fine ever since, and that was 8 months ago") are strong evidence of quality
- ✓ **Recency** — Reviews from the last 3 months signal an active, still-operating business
- ✓ **Volume** — More reviews from more sources means more evidence, which means more confidence from AI

How to ask for reviews without being awkward

The most effective time to ask for a review is immediately after a job is done and the customer is happy — not a week later in an email they've forgotten about. Here's what works:

Responding to reviews — don't skip this

Google tracks whether and how quickly you respond to reviews. Businesses that respond to reviews within 24 hours consistently outperform those that don't in AI local search — not because Google is rewarding politeness, but because responsiveness signals that a real, engaged business owner is behind the listing.

Responding to positive reviews

Keep it short and genuine. Thank the customer, mention the specific service or location if it was mentioned in their review (this adds more location/service keyword context to your GBP), and invite them back or wish them well.

Don't copy-paste the same response to every review. AI can detect template responses, and they're weighted lower than genuine, varied engagement.

Example positive review response: "Thank you so much for this, [Name]! Really glad the boiler installation went smoothly and that the house is warm again before the cold snap. If you ever need anything else in the Sheffield area, you know where we are."

Responding to negative reviews

This is where most businesses get it wrong. A bad review responded to professionally is actually a positive AI signal — it shows the business takes feedback seriously. An unanswered bad review is a negative signal.

1 Respond within 24 hours

The faster you respond, the better the signal — and the better it looks to human readers too.

2 Don't be defensive

Acknowledge the customer's experience even if you disagree with their version of events.

3 Take it offline

"We'd like to understand what happened — please call us on [number] so we can make this right." This shows good faith without airing everything publicly.

4 Never attack the reviewer

Section 6: Service areas — covering your actual patch

If your business travels to customers rather than having them come to you, service areas are how AI knows where you work. Set them correctly and you appear in every town you cover. Miss them and you only appear in your home area.

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

A plumber based in Sheffield who covers Rotherham, Barnsley, and Doncaster could be appearing in AI local searches across four towns. If they've only set their home address and no service areas, they only appear in Sheffield searches. They're leaving three towns' worth of AI visibility completely on the table.

How to set your service areas

1

Go to GBP dashboard → Edit profile → Service area

You'll see a map and a search box for adding areas.

2

Add every town, city, or postcode district you actually work in

Be specific — "Sheffield" and "Rotherham" as separate entries is better than just "South Yorkshire." The more specific your service areas, the better AI can match you to hyper-local searches.

3

Add up to 20 service areas

Google allows up to 20. If you genuinely cover 20 areas, add all of them.

4

Match your website coverage

Your service area in GBP should mirror the towns mentioned in your website content. Inconsistency between the two reduces trust.

Should I show my address or hide it?

If you work from home and don't want to display your home address, you can hide it in GBP while still being verified and fully visible. Here's how:

- 1 In GBP → Edit profile → Business location
- 2 Enter your address for verification purposes
- 3 Under "Show business address on your Business Profile," toggle this off
- 4 Your service areas will show instead of your address

HEADS UP

Businesses that serve customers both at a physical location AND travel to customers can list both — a physical address for people who come to you, plus service areas for the work you do on location. Use both settings if both apply to your business.

Section 7: How your GBP feeds AI beyond Google

Your Google Business Profile doesn't just affect Google search. It's used as a primary data source by ChatGPT, Perplexity, and other AI systems when they answer local business questions. Here's how that connection works.

When ChatGPT is asked "who's the best boiler engineer near me?" it doesn't just search Google — but it does access Google's local business data as one of its primary sources. Perplexity queries Google's local index directly. Apple Maps sources business data partially from Google. The information in your GBP essentially radiates outward across the AI ecosystem.

84M

shopping & local questions asked
to ChatGPT weekly in 2026

3×

more likely to appear in ChatGPT
local answers with a complete,
active GBP

60%

of Perplexity local business
answers cite Google business
data

The multiplier effect

Every improvement you make to your GBP has a multiplier effect across the AI ecosystem. When you add a better description, that better description doesn't just help Google AI Overviews — it also helps ChatGPT and Perplexity form more confident, accurate answers about your business.

When you add more detailed services, those services become discoverable not just on Google Maps but across every AI system that draws on Google's local data.

When you get a detailed review that mentions your location and what you fixed, that review becomes evidence in multiple AI systems' decisions about whether to recommend you.

This is why GBP is the single most important thing you can work on for AI visibility. It's not a Google-only strategy — it's a **cross-platform AI visibility strategy** that impacts every AI search tool your potential customers use.

The 7 GBP mistakes that kill AI visibility

These are the most common errors that local businesses make with their GBP — the ones that actively hold them back from appearing in AI local search. Check each one against your own profile.

1 Keyword stuffing in the business name

"Sheffield Plumber — Boilers & Heating" as a business name violates GBP policies and gets your listing suppressed. Use your real business name only.

2 Wrong or inconsistent address

Your address in GBP should be character-for-character identical to your address on your website. Even "Road" vs "Rd" creates an inconsistency that reduces AI trust.

3 No photos added in 30+ days

Activity signals matter. A stale photo library signals an inactive business. One new photo per week keeps your freshness score healthy.

4 Ignoring reviews — especially negative ones

Unanswered negative reviews are read by AI as evidence of poor customer service. Thoughtful responses turn them into demonstrations of professionalism.

5 Wrong primary category

If your category doesn't match your most important service, you'll be invisible for the searches that matter most. Review your category annually as your services evolve.

6 No posts in 30+ days

Posting is the clearest signal that your business is currently operating. Two posts per month is the minimum to maintain AI visibility.

7 Empty services section

The services section is your biggest opportunity to appear in service-specific AI searches. An empty services section is leaving enormous amounts of AI visibility on the table.

Reading your GBP Insights — how to know it's working

Google gives you data on how your GBP is performing inside the dashboard under "Performance." These numbers tell you whether your optimisation efforts are translating into actual visibility.

The metrics that matter

- ✓ **Search views** — How many times your business appeared in search results. This is your top-line visibility number. If it's growing month on month after your optimisation work, you're on the right track.
- ✓ **Map views** — How many times your business pin appeared on Google Maps. This tells you about map-based local searches.
- ✓ **Calls** — How many people called you directly from your GBP listing. This is the conversion that pays the bills.
- ✓ **Website clicks** — How many people clicked through to your website from GBP. Particularly useful if you track this in Google Analytics — you can see what those visitors do when they arrive.
- ✓ **Direction requests** — How many people asked for directions to your location from GBP. A strong signal for physical premises businesses.

What to look for

After completing your GBP optimisation, check your Insights every two to three weeks for the first three months. You're looking for an upward trend in search views — the first metric to improve after optimisation. Calls and website clicks typically follow within 4-8 weeks as the improved visibility translates into more engagement.

HEADS UP

GBP Insights data has a 3-5 day delay — you won't see real-time data. Also note that the insights don't separate AI Overview appearances from regular search appearances, though Google is gradually adding more granular reporting as AI features expand.

If your search views are flat or declining after 6-8 weeks of consistent posting and photo activity, it's usually a signal that either your category needs adjusting or your service area isn't matching the areas where searches are happening. Check both.

Your ongoing GBP maintenance routine

Getting your GBP set up properly is a one-time project. Keeping it effective is a simple, low-time weekly routine. Here's exactly what to do and when:

Every week (10 minutes)

- ✓ Add one new photo from the week's work
- ✓ Check for any new reviews and respond to all of them
- ✓ Check for any new Q&A questions and answer them

Every two weeks (15 minutes)

- ✓ Publish a GBP post (business update, recent job, or useful tip)
- ✓ Glance at your Insights — are views trending up?

Every month (30 minutes)

- ✓ Review your opening hours and update if anything has changed
- ✓ Check that all services listed are still accurate
- ✓ Look at which searches are driving traffic in Insights and consider whether your description or services reflect those searches

Every quarter (1 hour)

- ✓ Review your business description — is it still accurate? Does it mention your most profitable current services?
- ✓ Check your primary and secondary categories — have your services evolved?
- ✓ Review your service areas — are you regularly travelling to areas you haven't listed?
- ✓ Check for any duplicate listings and report them to Google

The total time investment is about **10-15 minutes per week** once you're set up. That's it. The businesses that win in AI local search aren't doing anything complicated — they're just doing the basics consistently, every week, when their competitors have forgotten their GBP exists.

Your GBP optimisation checklist

Work through these in order. Tick each one off as you complete it. The first 10 are your immediate priority — do them today if you can.

Claim & verify

☐ **Found or created your GBP listing** — searched Google Maps and business.google.com

☐ **Completed verification** — video, postcard, phone, or email

Essential fields

☐ **Business name** — exact legal trading name, no keywords added

☐ **Primary category** — most specific category that matches your core service

☐ **Secondary categories** — added for all other services you offer

☐ **Business description** — 750 chars, declarative sentences, specific facts about services and coverage

☐ **Address** — exactly as it appears on official correspondence

☐ **Phone number** — same number as on your website and everywhere else

☐ **Opening hours** — accurate, with special hours set for upcoming bank holidays

☐ **Website link** — your actual website homepage

☐ **Services** — 5+ individual services listed, each with a description

☐ **Service areas** — every town/area you genuinely work in (up to 20)

☐ **Attributes** — all applicable attributes ticked

Photos & media

- ☐ **Logo uploaded** — official business logo as a GBP logo photo
- ☐ **Exterior photo added** — your premises from outside (if applicable)
- ☐ **Interior/workspace photos added** — at least 2-3 showing your working environment
- ☐ **Work/product photos added** — at least 5 showing your actual work or products
- ☐ **Team photo added** — you and/or your team (even just you is fine)
- ☐ **Weekly photo habit started** — calendar reminder set for every week

Posts

- ☐ **First GBP post published** — business update with genuine content
- ☐ **Bi-weekly posting habit set up** — recurring calendar reminder in place

Reviews

- ☐ **All existing reviews responded to** — even old ones
- ☐ **Review request process in place** — know how and when you'll ask for reviews
- ☐ **Review link bookmarked** — the short link to your GBP review form saved for easy sharing

Q&A

- ☐ **Added 5+ Q&As** — seeded with your most common customer questions via Google Maps

Monitoring

- ☐ **GBP Insights reviewed** — baseline numbers noted for comparison next month
- ☐ **Weekly check habit set** — 10 minutes every week to check reviews, Q&A, and post

If you've ticked every item on this checklist, your GBP is in the top 10% of local business profiles for AI visibility. Most of your competitors have maybe half of these done. You've just built a significant advantage.

You've built your foundation

Your Google Business Profile is now working as hard as it can for you. You've given Google's AI everything it needs to start recommending your business — a complete profile, specific services, accurate location data, and the activity signals that prove you're a real, currently-operating business.

But GBP is only one piece of the AI visibility puzzle. The second piece is something that even the most beautifully optimised GBP can't replace: consistent information about your business across the entire web.

AI systems don't just read your GBP in isolation. They cross-reference it against dozens of other data sources — Yelp, Facebook, TripAdvisor, Apple Maps, Yell, Checkatrade, and hundreds of industry-specific directories. Every time your business name, address, or phone number appears differently on one of these platforms, it creates a contradiction — and AI systems are less likely to recommend businesses whose "facts" don't add up.

COMING UP NEXT

Module 3: NAP Consistency — How to Make Every Directory Work Together

In Module 3, you'll audit every place your business appears online, find the inconsistencies that are reducing your AI visibility right now, and fix them permanently — using a simple process that takes one afternoon and keeps working for years.

- Why AI treats inconsistent business information like a red flag
- The 15 directories that matter most for AI local search in 2026
- How to find every place your business is listed online (including ones you didn't create)
- The step-by-step process for updating every listing efficiently
- How to prevent new inconsistencies from appearing automatically

Useful resources

Everything you need to complete your GBP optimisation — all free, all legitimate.



Google Business Profile Dashboard

business.google.com

Your GBP management centre. Everything in this guide is done here.



Your GBP Review Link

business.google.com → [Share profile](#) → [Get more reviews](#)

The direct link to send to customers so they can leave a review in one click. Bookmark and save this.



Google Rich Results Test

search.google.com/test/rich-results

Check what structured data Google can see on your website. Useful when you get to Module 4.



Google Maps (for Q&A)

maps.google.com — [search your business](#) → [Questions & Answers](#)

Use this to add your own Q&As to your GBP. Can only be done via Maps, not the dashboard.



GBP Category Research

[Search Google Maps for your competitors and check their displayed categories](#)

The best way to find the most effective category for your business type in your area.



GBP Performance Insights

business.google.com → [Performance](#)

Your visibility metrics — search views, direction requests, calls, and website clicks. Check monthly.



AI Search School Community

skool.com/ai-search-school-6151/about

Free community for questions, GBP reviews, and support from other local businesses working through this series.

The complete series

Module 2 is one of five guides in the Get Found in AI Local Search series. Each one is standalone — you'll get full value from just this guide. But together, the five modules take you from complete AI invisibility to being the local business that AI search recommends first.

01

Why Local Search Is Going AI — The big picture shift and why it matters for your business right now

02

Your Google Business Profile — You are here. Set up for the AI era.

03

NAP Consistency — Making every directory work together so AI trusts your information

04

Your Website for AI — Building a site that AI can read, trust, and recommend

05

Reviews and Reputation — Getting and using reviews that make AI recommend you over everyone else

Each guide is £9. The full 5-guide bundle is available as a discounted bundle — find it in the AI Search School store.

Questions as you work through this? The [AI Search School community](https://skool.com/ai-search-school-6151) at skool.com/ai-search-school-6151 is free to join. Post a screenshot of your GBP, ask what to fix next, and get eyes from other business owners working through the same process.



Your GBP is ready. Now let's make it **impossible to ignore.**

Module 3 is where consistency becomes your competitive advantage. Claim it at the AI Search School store.

FIND ALL GUIDES AT
aisearchschool.com/guides

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